BENEATH THE MASK

Pratik Gandhi on his role as a morally grey spy in period thriller *Saare Jahan Se Accha*

Five years ago, Pratik Gandhi had his career breakthrough with *Scam 1992*. He's been a busy bee since, casting a spell on both streaming and the big screen (*Madgaon Express*, *Do Dooni Chaar*). Which makes it all the more surprising that it's only now that he's making his Netflix series debut with *Saare Jahan Se Accha*. "We were both waiting for something to work on together," says Gandhi, who found the "perfect script" in the 1960s-set spy thriller. For Tanya Bami, Netflix India's series head, it was about time. "If we had our way, we would have had Pratik come on to a series way sooner."

Just don't bet on rooting for the spy he portrays. Gandhi quotes a line from the show to explain: "A good human being cannot be a good spy." "There's a constant conflict, a moral dilemma, a line that he wants to cross, but is not able to," notes Gandhi. "He wants to be the country's biggest asset and save it, but the other side of his character is difficult to ignore." A patriot he may be, but leading a duplicitous life takes a toll, especially on his marital life (Tillotama Shome plays the wife). Bami applauded Gandhi's "intensity", which was evident in *Scam* too. "Here, he is an earnest character, there's an emotionality, he's testing his limits and the cost at which it comes," she adds.

Much like *Raazi*, *Saare Jahan Se Accha* also busts some tropes of the genre and aims for a not-so-lionising character study. There's no jumping off rooftops, fancy gadgets or gun battles here to highlight hypermasculinity. If anything, the show emphasises on the vocation's need to evade attention at any cost. Says Gandhi, "Spies lead complex lives. You are constantly driven by your intuitions. You have so much information and lots going on inside, but can't say a single word." The ability to explore the deep intricacies is why Bami and her team felt the story lent itself well to the longer format. "There have been flamboyant takes of the genre, but we haven't delved much into a human-first, emotion-first way. That's the attempt."

Given the title, it's hardly surprising that Netflix opted for an Independence Day release, the long weekend offering an incentive for viewers to binge the six episodes. With Sunny Hinduja (of TVF's *Aspirants* fame) as the ISI counterpart to Gandhi's R&AW agent, the hope is the cat-and-mouse game between the two keeps viewers hooked. Gandhi, who has already played social reformer Jyotirao Phule earlier this year and appears as Mahatma Gandhi in his next, *Saare Jahan Se Accha* enables him to essay another ideal Indian of sorts. "Spies are unsung heroes," he adds. "I feel we are celebrating their success, [something] that's traditionally never done." ■

—Suhani Singh

By not lionising its protagonist, **the show focuses on how spies need to evade attention at any cost,** busting the genre's hypermasculine tropes

